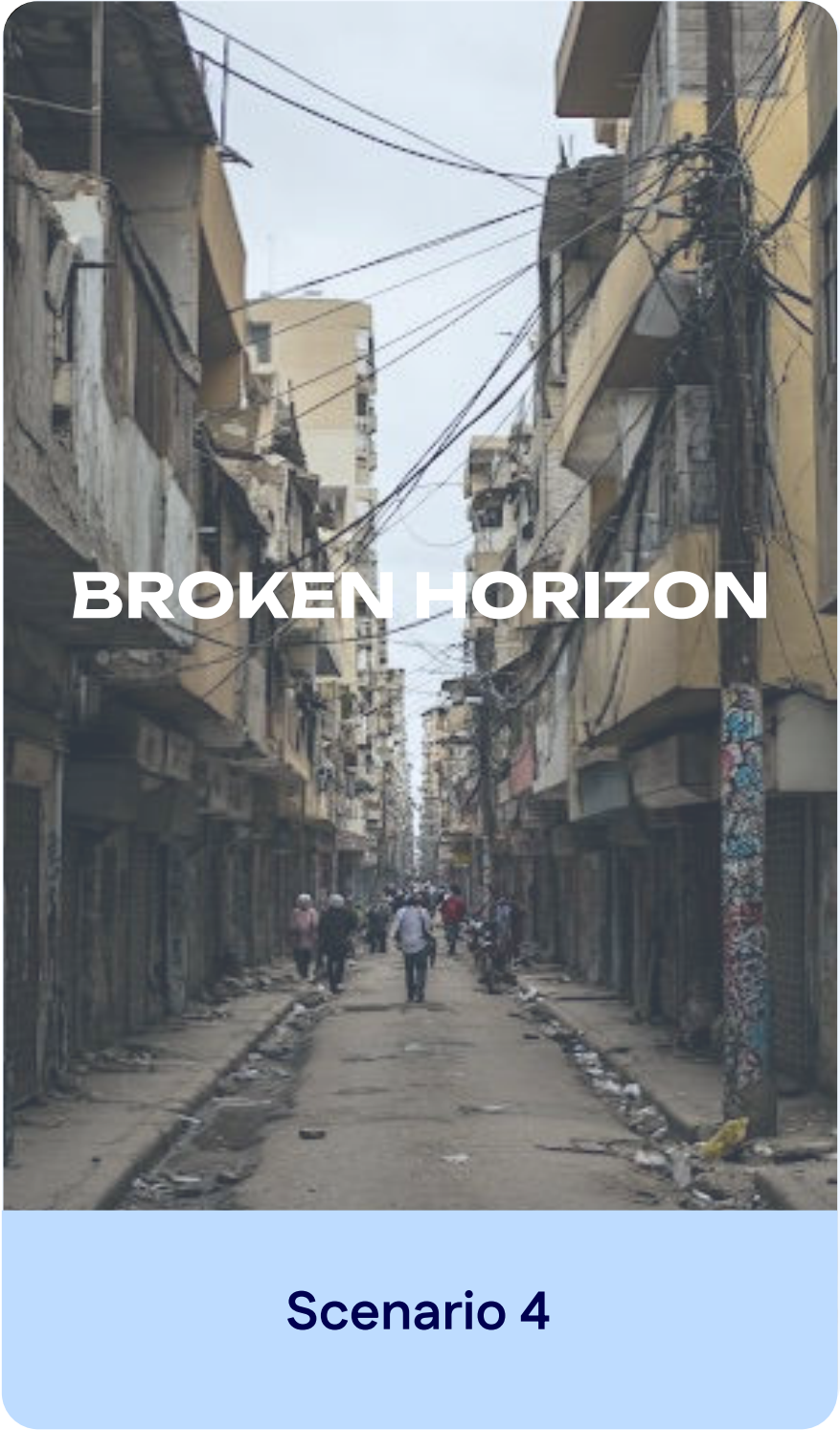




CITIES OF THE FUTURE – ALTERNATIVE SCENARIOS

Draft Documentation for discussion on Wednesday, March 05th 2025

ALTERNATIVE SCENARIOS FOR 2035 | CITIES OF THE FUTURE





Scenario 1

HARMONY IN MOTION



Scenario 1

HARMONY IN MOTION

Active citizen engagement

Financial resilience and equitable growth

Collaborative governance and innovation

Key Points:

- Citizen activism and public-private partnerships drive urban transformation.
- AI and citizen feedback shape policies, making city planning more responsive.
- Shift toward human-centric design, neighborhoods are multifunctional and community-driven.
- Public transport is free, fast, and seamlessly connected through mobility hubs.
- Local businesses thrive, turning retail into social and community experiences.
- Renewable energy and sustainability efforts dominate, but waste management and climate adaptation still face challenges.
- Housing is flexible, with shared spaces, co-living, and sustainable designs.
- AI and robotics enhance public services, supporting mobility, safety, and urban maintenance.
- AI supports governance, but tensions over privacy, labor rights, and corporate influence persist.
- The city constantly evolves—people, policies, and technology shaping its future.

Facts and Figures:



The decidim citizen participation platform is used in 30 countries, incl. by cities like Barcelona, Mexico City and NYC ([decidim](#))



Car traffic inside Paris decreased by 50% between 2002 and 2022, while cycling traffic increased by 71% from 2019 to 2022 ([ITDP](#))



More than 35 countries worldwide currently provide all or some of its public transport for free. ([freepublictransport](#))

A city alive with movement on a bumpy road toward a smart, inclusive, and sustainable city.

By 2035, the city thrives as a dynamic ecosystem where governance, innovation, and community action converge to shape an inclusive and resilient urban landscape. Public and private sectors collaborate to drive progress, ensuring that economic growth aligns with social well-being. Smart regulations and strategic investments have modernized infrastructure, blending AI-driven efficiency with sustainable design to create a city that works for its people.

City transformation comes from its citizens— they engage through digital platforms that allow real-time feedback on policies, shaping city planning alongside policymakers. Misinformation once threatened this progress, but AI-driven fact-checking systems now filter out noise, ensuring informed decision-making. Private corporations play a central role in urban development, driving innovation and economic growth, yet their influence sparks debates on affordability and labor rights.

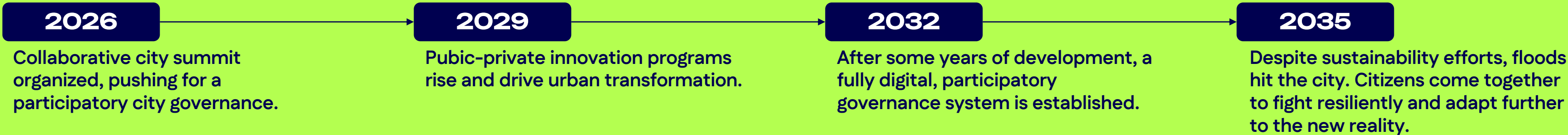
Streets hum with quiet electric vehicles, while wide green corridors weave through towering vertical districts, bringing nature into the heart of urban life. Skyscrapers blend traditional motives with cutting-edge materials, reflecting both the city's heritage and its global connections. Beneath the surface, underground transit hubs and automated logistics networks keep the city flowing, ensuring efficiency without overwhelming public spaces.

At the core of the city's progress is a shift toward human-centric design, where neighborhoods are more multifunctional and community-driven than ever. Public spaces evolve to meet local needs, blending flexible work, leisure, and social areas to foster connection and accessibility. AI and robotics enhance public services, supporting mobility, safety, and urban maintenance—yet their integration is shaped by ongoing discussions on privacy, labor, and governance. While technology optimizes daily life, its adoption varies across sectors, requiring participatory decision-making to balance innovation with affordability and inclusivity.

Sustainability efforts are evident everywhere. Public transport is nearly emission-free, and energy grids are powered by a mix of solar, wind, and biofuels. Cities have made significant strides in climate adaptation, implementing measures to mitigate risks, but the impact of climate change persists. While some strategies successfully prevent disasters, others fall short against the increasing intensity of extreme weather, leading to ongoing challenges with infrastructure, flooding, and pollution. Waste management, despite advancements, still lags behind rising consumption, forcing constant innovation in recycling and circular economy models.



How do we get here?



Society & Lifestyle

The city is a mosaic of cultures, backgrounds, and ages, where diversity fuels a vibrant urban life. Neighborhoods blend generations and incomes, fostering inclusivity and social mobility. Digital tools enhance convenience, while people cherish personal routines—morning café rituals, community gatherings, and shared green spaces. Luxury is redefined, shifting from material wealth to well-being, knowledge, and time. Safety, resilience, and a strong sense of belonging shape the city's identity, ensuring a high quality of life.

Mobility

Seamless, sustainable, and shared – mobility is no longer about ownership but accessibility. AI-powered public transit, self-driving shuttles, and integrated mobility hubs ensure smooth, efficient travel. Car-free city centers prioritize people over vehicles, with bike lanes and pedestrian zones dominating urban spaces. Free public transport, financed through innovative models, makes movement effortless and equitable. With fewer private cars, streets become vibrant social spaces, reinforcing the city's commitment to connectivity and collective well-being.

Business & Retail

Commerce seamlessly blends with culture, transforming business districts into dynamic spaces that shift from work hubs by day to social hotspots by night. Local businesses thrive through curated retail experiences, offering expertise and personalized advice beyond simple transactions. Shopping is no longer just about acquiring goods but about connection—turning stores into places of discovery and engagement. People seek out familiar vendors—their trusted barista who knows their order, the local grocer who greets them by name—fostering a sense of belonging, loyalty, and community trust.

Construction & Architecture

The cityscape blends the past and future, with retrofitted buildings standing alongside vertical, green-powered structures. Sustainable materials and modular designs create adaptable spaces, ensuring flexibility for changing needs. Multi-generational co-living and shared facilities redefine housing, fostering inclusion and affordability. Companies invest in housing for employees and students, strengthening urban communities. Rooftop gardens, water features, and shaded pathways combat climate change, making the city both functional and beautiful.

Infrastructure & Energy

The city thrives on a dynamic, demand-driven energy system, where smart grids balance consumption and sustainability. Renewables dominate, with citizen-led energy production turning homes and businesses into power hubs. Shared data and computing centers optimize energy use for companies, while free public internet ensures connectivity for all. Water and electricity systems are highly efficient, supported by IoT-powered monitoring. Resilience is key—backup energy sources and decentralized networks protect against disruptions, keeping the city running no matter the challenge.

Legislation & Governance

Governance is transparent, participatory, and data-driven. Decentralized systems ensure efficiency, with AI-enhanced decision-making supporting democratic processes. Citizens play an active role through digital referendums and public consultations, ensuring policies reflect collective needs. Legislation promotes sustainability, urban innovation, and social equity, balancing private sector growth with public interest. While global governance debates persist, this city remains a model for collaboration, where technology strengthens democracy rather than replacing it.



Examples of Today:



Copenhagen, Denmark

The Nordhavn district showcases the "five-minute city" concept, integrating car-free zones, diverse architecture, and green initiatives to create a pedestrian-friendly neighborhood. This design fosters community engagement and environmental sustainability. [Link](#)



Masdar City, United Arab Emirates

Initiated in 2006 the city is designed as a hub for sustainable innovation. It integrates renewable energy, green building practices, and advanced technology, aiming to minimize environmental impact while promoting research and development in clean technologies. [Link](#)



Medellin, Colombia

Despite it's troubled past, Medellín was awarded the World's Most Innovative City in 2013 and has since become a role model for other metropolises. It transformed through urban renewal projects focusing on advanced and accessible public transport and vibrant community spaces, various education initiatives and community programs. [Link](#)

Despite some tensions, the city thrives on collaboration. It is not perfect, nor is it utopian. It is a living, evolving system where people, policies, and technology continuously negotiate the future.

Can we ensure equitable access to innovation? Will sustainability keep pace with growth? And how do we protect privacy in a connected world? The city's strength lies in its people—collaborating, adapting, and shaping a future where progress serves everyone.



Scenario 2

CORPORATE ARCHIPELAGO



Scenario 2

CORPORATE ARCHIPELAGO

Corporate dominance

Deepening social divide

Innovation for the privileged

Key Points:

- _ Tech giants control daily life, running transport, energy, and public services for profit.
- _ Wealth decides access—luxury districts thrive, while poorer areas crumble.
- _ AI monitors streets, with drones and facial recognition gates restricting movement.
- _ Housing shortages push lower-income workers to outskirts, while the rich live in gated communities.
- _ Green energy powers elite districts, but poorer areas rely on failing fossil-fuel grids.
- _ Corporations shape laws, elections favor the wealthy, and citizen voices fade.
- _ Small businesses disappear as AI-driven marketplaces fuel corporate monopolies.
- _ The rich glide through the city in self-driving cars and air taxis—others face broken transit.
- _ Disaster protection is privatized—climate resilience comes at a price.
- _ The skyline shines, but the streets tell a different story—one city, two worlds.

Facts and Figures:



State and local governments in the US spent at least \$30 billion a year on business tax incentives, with the majority going to a small portion of firms ([Princeton](#))



Cape Town reflects South Africa’s extreme inequality, as the country ranks as the most unequal in the world with a Gini coefficient of 0.67 in 2018 ([World Bank](#)).



32 million households are expected to be living in gated communities in India’s top-50 cities in 2031, about 50% of all households in these cities ([redseer](#))

A city of progress racing into the future, but divided by power and privilege, leaving many behind.

By 2035, the city is shaped by three powerful forces: big companies control daily life, money decides who gets opportunities, and technology moves forward—but only for those who can afford it. Tech giants now run essential services like transport and energy, making life smoother for some but shutting others out. The gap between rich and poor is wider than ever, turning neighborhoods into either luxury zones or areas of hardship. Innovation happens quickly, but only where it benefits business, leaving many parts of the city behind.

Glass skyscrapers shine with digital billboards, symbols of the tech corporations that now have more power than the government. Public services—once available to everyone—are now run by private companies, making them more advanced but also more expensive. Wealthy districts have high-tech homes that adapt to their owners' needs, with AI-powered temperature control, vertical gardens, and clean energy systems. Meanwhile, the poorer areas are packed with people, buildings falling apart as the city struggles to keep up with demand.

Drones patrol the streets, promising safety but taking away privacy. In wealthier zones, facial recognition gates decide who can enter, keeping public spaces exclusive.

The city's economy runs on digital platforms, where everything from transport to healthcare is sold as a service. AI takes over many jobs, making life easier for some but leaving many unemployed, leading to frustration and protests in struggling communities.

Different neighborhoods create their own identities—some protect their culture through small, independent leadership, while others turn into global business hubs, shaped by the corporations funding them. Green parks grow in rich areas, blending nature with modern design. Meanwhile, poorer districts deal with constant waste problems, as recycling programs fail to keep up with demand.

Cities fight to attract investment, removing regulations to allow companies to test new ideas. In rich neighborhoods, self-driving cars move smoothly through clean streets, while people in poorer areas rely on overcrowded public transport. Housing shortages push lower-income workers and migrants to the city's edges, where resources are limited, and opportunities are few. Despite promises of a greener future, financial struggles slow down sustainability efforts. High-tech infrastructure makes parts of the city more resistant to climate change, but at a price many cannot afford.



How do we get here?



Society & Lifestyle

The city's heart beats in bustling commercial hubs, where shopping centers double as social arenas filled with entertainment and networking opportunities. The wealthy enjoy exclusive business and leisure districts, while lower-income groups navigate overcrowded areas with fewer resources. Heritage is showcased in grand cultural projects, but access is limited—certain areas are only open to those with the right credentials. Trust in institutions declines, fueling tensions between rich and poor. Neighborhood initiatives emerge on digital platforms, fostering hyper-local communities.

Mobility

Mobility is defined by wealth. The rich glide through the city in autonomous electric vehicles or private air taxis, enjoying seamless, AI-optimized routes. Exclusive micro-mobility options, like e-scooters and smart bikes, are available in luxury districts. In contrast, poorer areas rely on outdated public transit and fossil-fuel-powered transport, struggling with congestion and inefficiency. Competing mobility services fight for dominance, but accessibility remains a privilege, not a right.

Business & Retail

Retail is an immersive digital experience, blending e-commerce with interactive AI-driven marketplaces. Local businesses struggle against corporate giants, leading to mergers and acquisitions that strengthen monopolies. Data isn't just collected—it's monetized, acting as both currency and a means of control. Cities compete fiercely to attract corporations, granting them influence over regulations. Innovation hubs flourish, but only in elite districts, reinforcing the divide between economic winners and those left behind.

Construction & Architecture

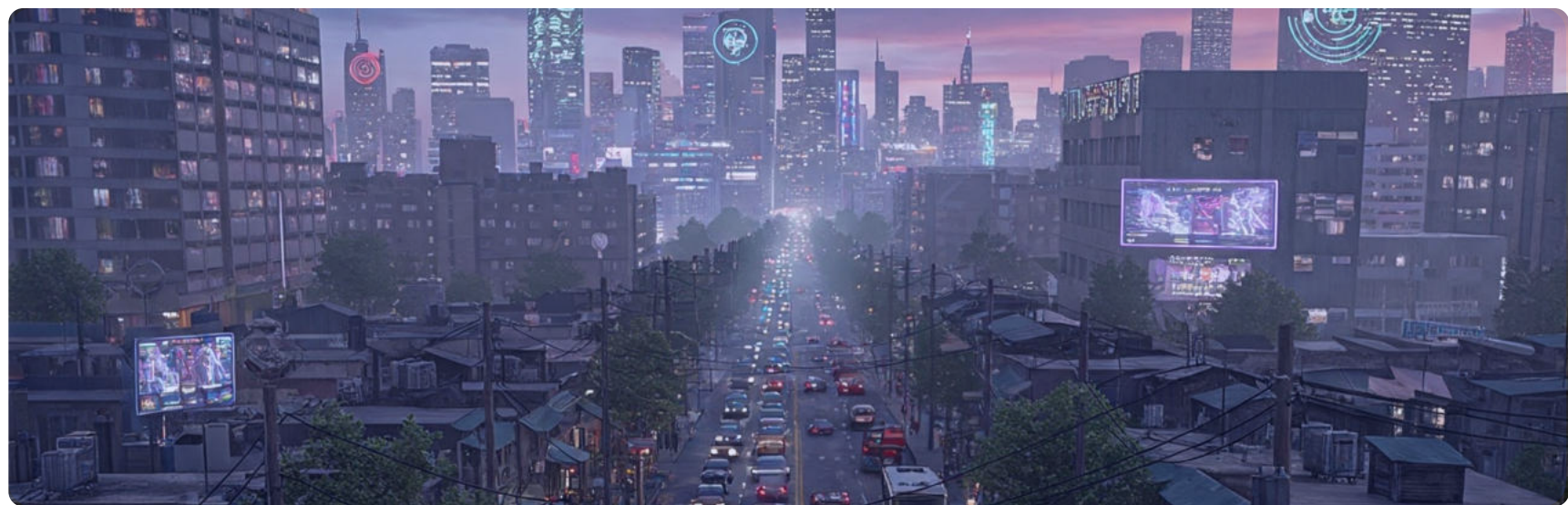
In elite districts, sleek skyscrapers boast modular designs, climate-controlled interiors, and lush rooftop gardens—symbols of prestige and power. Surveillance is built into every structure, ensuring control over movement. Meanwhile, the outskirts sprawl with makeshift, overcrowded housing. Adaptive living spaces emerge for a mobile workforce, while corporations gain control over critical infrastructure, "saving" flood-prone areas in exchange for unchecked influence.

Infrastructure & Energy

The city's infrastructure is a patchwork of innovation and neglect. Wealthy districts run on smart grids powered by renewable energy, while older neighborhoods struggle with outdated fossil-fuel systems. Private corporations dominate utilities, controlling water, waste, and electricity distribution with profit-driven efficiency. Energy trading platforms allow the affluent to buy and sell excess power, while lower-income areas face unreliable services. Disaster resilience is privatized, with premium protection plans available for those who can afford them.

Legislation & Governance

Governance is shaped by corporate influence and growing social divisions. Surveillance expands under the guise of public safety, yet crime in neglected areas continues to rise. Elections are won by the highest bidders, as wealthy candidates outspend rivals in massive campaigns. AI-driven decision-making accelerates innovation, but with minimal oversight, tech giants gain unchecked power. While megacities and corporations form unofficial alliances to shape global policy, the average citizen finds it harder to influence decisions that shape their daily lives.



Examples of Today:



Istanbul, Turkey

In 2017, the city had the highest income disparity in the country, with the richest 20% earning 8.2 times more than the poorest 20%. This disparity has led to pronounced divisions between affluent neighborhoods and impoverished areas. The Gini coefficient for Istanbul was 0.443. [Link](#)



San Francisco, USA

The city's tech boom has led to significant gentrification, with affluent tech workers driving up living costs and displacing long-term residents. This has created a stark divide between wealthy tech employees and lower-income communities. [Link](#)



Fortaleza, Brazil

As one of the most unequal cities globally, Fortaleza faces significant housing disparities, with affluent areas juxtaposed against vast informal settlements, highlighting the city's deep social and economic divides. [Link](#)

The skyline shines with progress, but at street level, the reality is clear—one city, two different worlds, growing further apart every day.

As corporations tighten their grip, the gap widens, and the human cost grows. Can a city thrive when so many are left behind? What happens when progress excludes the people it's meant to serve? The future is here, but who does it truly belong to?



Scenario 3

TECH SYMPHONY



Scenario 3

TECH SYMPHONY

High-tech for well-being

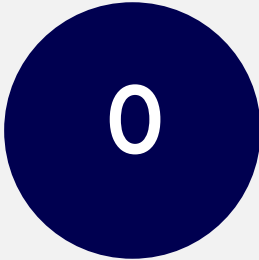
People-Centered Societies

Nature-Integrated Living

Key Points:

- The city is an AI-driven organism that adapts to the needs of its inhabitants.
- Access is exclusive, granted to those who align with the city's values of collective well-being, and sustainability.
- Technology enhances well-being, automating tasks and optimizing personal health and schedules.
- Ownership is replaced by shared access, with on-demand mobility and decentralized currencies.
- Intergenerational neighborhoods self-sustaining, with AI-guided urban farms and mixed-reality spaces.
- Governance is decentralized, with AI and blockchain ensuring real-time adaptation and allowing citizens to shape policies through digital platforms.
- Sustainability is a foundation, with waste transformation, renewable energy, and nature embedded in urban design.
- Business thrives on adaptability, with circular economies and data-driven insights guiding commerce.
- Movement is seamless, with autonomous vehicles, drones, and robots handling transport and logistics.
- Vertical forests, underground developments, and responsive architecture form a city in harmony with nature.

Facts and Figures:



Zero rubbish trucks drive around Songdo, all household and office waste is sucked through a network of underground tubes to vast sorting facilities ([BBC](#))



The largest vertical garden (green wall) measures 2,289 m², covers 24-storeys and was achieved by City Developments Limited in Singapore ([WEF](#))



More than 50% of government operations in Dubai are now conducted via blockchain, ensuring security and transparency ([HiDubaiFocus](#))

A city that thinks, adapts, and thrives—where technology empowers, nature flourishes, and people truly live.

The city of 2035 hums with quiet intelligence, its rhythm dictated by a seamless blend of technology, human ingenuity, and nature's quiet resurgence. The old chaos of urban life has been replaced by a symphony of interconnected systems—digital, ecological, and social—working in harmony. The city is not just a place to live but an organism that responds, adapts, and evolves with its inhabitants. Technology enhances well-being, automation liberates time, and nature is not an afterthought but an integral force shaping daily life. Yet, to preserve this balance, the city remains highly selective—accessible only to those who align with its ethos.

Every street and building is connected by an AI-driven infrastructure that monitors air quality, optimizes energy, and prevents disruptions before they occur. Autonomous vehicles move through specialized lanes, while drone networks handle logistics. AI assistants predict personal needs, managing health, schedules, and even leisure, curating hyper-personalized experiences.

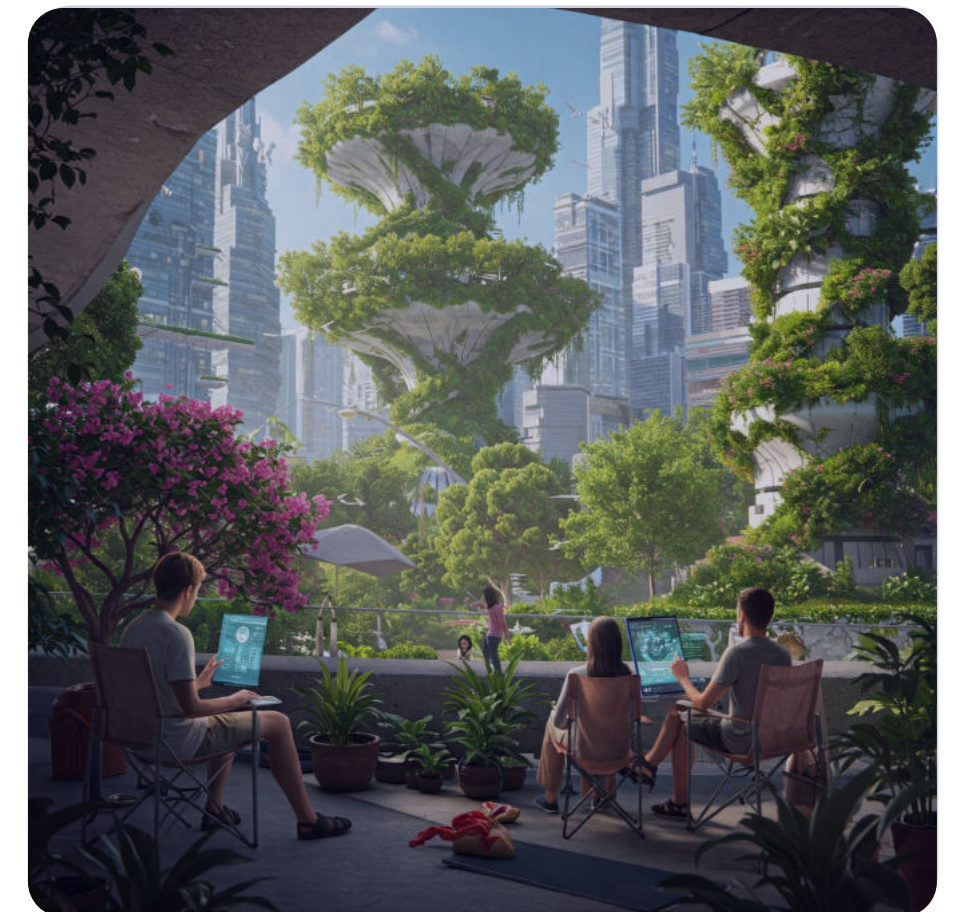
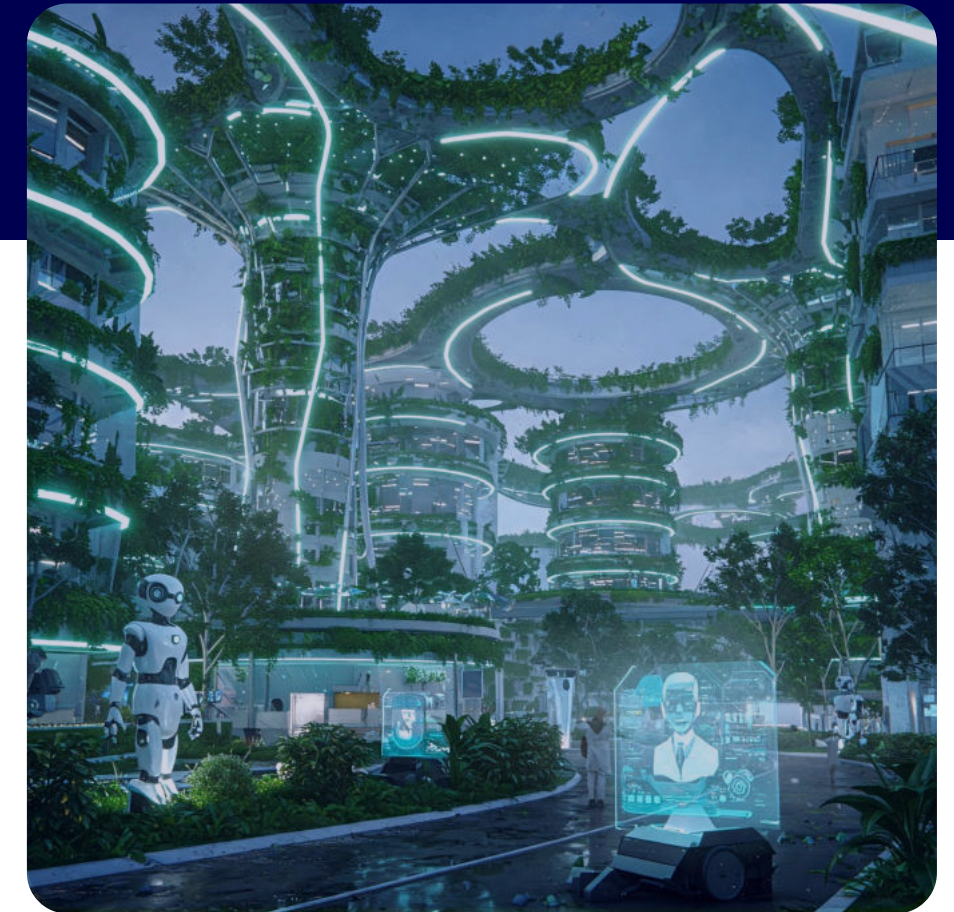
Ownership has given way to shared access. Mobility is on demand, AI coordinates resource-sharing, and decentralized digital currencies enable seamless exchange. A universal basic income ensures financial security, allowing people to focus on learning, creativity, and purpose.

Neighborhoods function as self-sustaining hubs—walkable, intergenerational, and adaptable. AI-guided urban farms provide hyper-local food, while mixed-reality spaces blur digital and physical worlds. Robots manage routine tasks, and predictive healthcare prevents illness before it starts, seamlessly integrating virtual and in-person care.

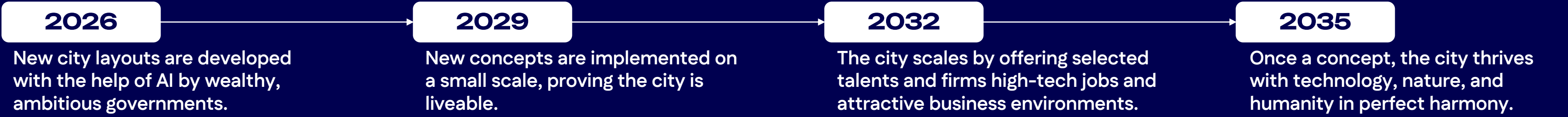
Governance is decentralized, powered by blockchain-backed contracts and AI-assisted regulations that adapt in real-time. City-owned digital platforms ensure efficient public services, reducing corporate monopolies and enhancing citizen involvement. These systems also facilitate public decision making regarding new entrants based on their skills, values and on demonstrated commitment to collective well-being, sustainability, and continuous learning.

Sustainability is not a goal but a foundation. Waste doesn't exist—only resources in perpetual transformation. Renewable energy flows through smart grids, and carbon-neutral buildings regulate themselves. Nature is deeply embedded into the city, with vertical forests, green rooftops, and wildlife corridors shaping the skyline.

Despite deep digital integration, human connection remains central. People own less but experience more, enriched not by material excess, but by time, community, and a sense of belonging.



How do we get here?



Society & Lifestyle

Life in the city flows seamlessly between physical and digital realms, allowing people to prioritize well-being, purpose, and connection. Digital avatars handle routine tasks, freeing time for creativity and leisure. Five generations live side by side, supported by AI-powered assistants anticipating personal needs, managing schedules, optimizing health, and curating escapism and meaningful experiences tailored to each individual. Nature is no longer a backdrop but a respected co-inhabitant, shaping daily life alongside technology.

Mobility

Movement is fluid, efficient, and nearly invisible. Walkable communities minimize the need for transport, while autonomous electric vehicles glide underground and through the sky. Drones and robotic systems handle logistics, reducing congestion. AI synchronizes all mobility, ensuring zero wait times and emissions. With hyper-local production and digital avatars attending meetings, people travel less—but when they do, it’s effortless, with three-dimensional transit weaving through the urban landscape.

Business & Retail

Business thrives on adaptability and sustainability. AI-driven planning ensures neighborhoods host the right mix of commerce, nature, and people. Circular economies replace wasteful models, with citizens co-creating, producing, and exchanging goods. Hybrid retail spaces blend AR/VR with physical interaction, turning shopping into an experience. Profit is measured not only in revenue but in sustainability—businesses reinvest earnings into regenerating nature. Local businesses flourish through data-driven insights, anticipating needs before they arise.

Construction & Architecture

The city rises in harmony with nature, blending extreme verticality with underground developments to maximize space. AI-driven design adapts structures to environmental shifts, preventing floods and optimizing energy use. Buildings are crafted only from renewable materials, self-regulating temperature and air quality. Neighborhoods develop organically, with no single center—public spaces adapt to community needs, shifting layouts in real time. Architecture reflects a living ecosystem, where green corridors and urban forests merge seamlessly with digital environments.

Infrastructure & Energy

The city thrives on self-sustaining, clean energy seamlessly embedded in its landscape. Roads, buildings, and even furniture generate power through solar and kinetic sources, reducing reliance on centralized grids. AI-driven smart grids anticipate demand, ensuring ultra-efficient energy distribution with minimal waste. Waste and water systems are circular, purifying and reusing resources locally. Resilient microgrids protect against cyberattacks and climate disruptions, keeping the city running smoothly with near-zero emissions and decentralized, community-owned energy hubs.

Legislation & Governance

Governance is decentralized and participatory, with AI and blockchain ensuring transparency. Citizens actively shape policies through digital platforms, balancing personal autonomy with collective well-being. Data ownership rests with individuals, allowing them to control how their information is used. Environmental laws are strict, enforced by automated monitoring systems that prevent violations in real time. Universal Basic Income guarantees financial stability, while AI-driven surveillance protects public spaces—maintaining order in a city where entry is a privilege, not a right.



Examples of Today:



Songdo, South Korea
The city is a purpose-built smart city spanning 1,500 acres. It features advanced infrastructure, including LEED-certified buildings, integrated waste management systems, and extensive green spaces. They aim to serve as a model for sustainable urban development. [Link](#)



The Line, Saudi Arabia
Part of the NEOM project, The Line is a planned linear city that emphasizes high-tech urban living with integrated AI systems, sustainable energy solutions, and a design that eliminates the need for cars. [Link](#)



Singapore
The city-state employs a Smart Nation initiative, integrating IoT devices, autonomous public transport, and smart energy management systems to enhance urban living. [Link](#)

In this city, technology, nature, and humanity move as one. AI and digital tools free people to focus on what truly matters, while nature is woven into every aspect of life. Innovation drives progress, yet values shape its direction.

But as society changes, what defines belonging? How do we ensure no one is left behind? And in a world that constantly adapts, what should always remain the same?



Scenario 4

BROKEN HORIZON



Scenario 4

BROKEN HORIZON

Government Collapse

Stagnant Industry & Lack of Innovation

Mass Migration & Urban Decay

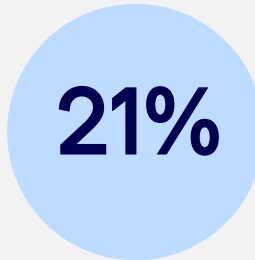
Key Points:

- Government reliance on outdated automation systems causes frequent failures in public services.
- The economy fragments as big companies leave, innovation lacks and underground trade thrives.
- Mass migration leaves ghost towns behind, while those who stay survive in underground economies.
- Law enforcement is minimal, leaving security to industrial firms protecting their assets rather than citizens.
- Water shortages and blackouts force people to rely on costly black-market supplies.
- Crime surges due to job losses, food shortages, and lack of social support.
- Public transport is unreliable, with broken buses and abandoned metro stations.
- Pollution and waste have reached critical levels, leading to mounting health risks.
- Social life fractures into distrust, isolation, and shrinking communities.
- Protests erupt over wages and services, but corporate security and surveillance suppress dissent.

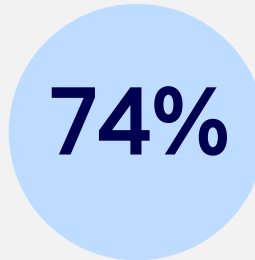
Facts and Figures:



As of April 2015 in Yemen, over 13 million civilians lacked access to clean water due to ongoing conflict, leading many to purchase water from unregulated vendors at high prices. ([TheGuardian](#))



In 10 years, Flint’s (US) population decreased by nearly 21%.This decline is attributed to crime, job losses, and the lead-contaminated water crisis. ([DetroitNews](#))



Between 2013 and 2023, Venezuela experienced a 74% decline in living standards. As decades of economic mismanagement and sanctions devastated the nation's economy. ([economicsobservatory](#))

A city failing to adapt, where people stay within their neighborhood borders and survival is a struggle.

By 2035, this city is a relic of the past, crumbling under the weight of stagnation and neglect. It has failed to modernize, driving out those who sought better opportunities elsewhere. Those that remained lacked the resources or incentive to modernize, accelerating the economic downturn. As industries faltered, jobs disappeared, and waves of migration drained the population, what's left behind is a shrinking workforce and an aging, vulnerable society. The government, overwhelmed and ineffective, failed to intervene, allowing essential services and infrastructure to deteriorate. What remains is a fragmented, unsustainable city.

With businesses relocating to more prosperous regions, employment opportunities have dwindled, resulting in a fragmented economy. While some industries, including manufacturing, logistics, and resource extraction, still operate, they fail to provide stability, fair wages, and innovate ideas. Young people flee in search of better futures, leaving behind an aging population with no choice but to endure. Crime festers in the void left by public sector collapse, turning districts into lawless zones where residents live cautiously, hiding their valuables to avoid becoming targets.

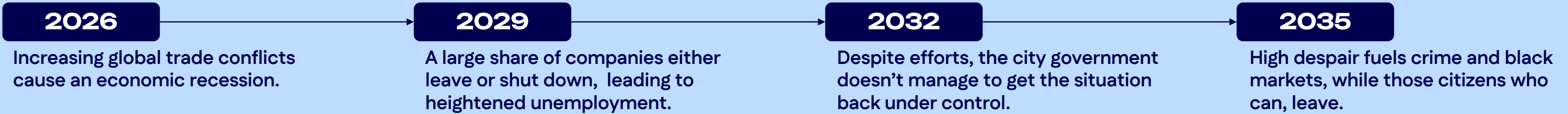
Automation has replaced human workers in administration, transport, and even healthcare—not as a means of progress, but as a cost-cutting measure. Outdated systems, neglected maintenance, and lack of investment have stalled any real development. Healthcare is now limited to automated clinics, cold and impersonal, capable only of handling routine care. Air pollution has reached critical levels, forcing residents to wear masks outdoors.

In better areas, locals and small business maintain minimal living conditions, but other districts are left with toxic environments, collapsing waste systems, and trash piles that breed disease and infestations. Entire neighborhoods have become ghost towns as migration drains the population. Those who remain form informal networks, relying on black-market goods and underground economies for survival.

Protests erupt frequently as people fight for fair wages and basic services. What was once a thriving urban center is now a cautionary tale of unchecked privatization, systemic inequality, and urban decay. The future is uncertain, but for many, there is no way out.



How do we get here?



Society & Lifestyle

The city is in a state of social fragmentation, where distrust defines daily life. Without a strong community or reliable institutions, people live in isolation, avoiding unnecessary interactions. Family sizes have shrunk, and migration has torn apart social networks, leaving behind those unable to relocate. Cultural life has faded, replaced by underground or small spaces where people gather with people they know, wary of attracting unwanted attention. Public life is rare, as the streets are unsafe, mostly during the night, and the lack of law enforcement means self-reliance is the only path to survival.

Mobility

Transportation infrastructure has collapsed, with abandoned highways and skeletal transit systems barely functioning. The remaining buses run unpredictably, and most metro stations are derelict, overrun by decay and vandalism. Those who can afford it rely on personal vehicles, navigating roads filled with debris and deteriorating bridges. Fuel shortages make transport unreliable, and without sustainable alternatives, pollution worsens. For most, commuting is a struggle, and moving between districts is a dangerous necessity rather than a convenience.

Business & Retail

The economic landscape is defined by desperation and informal survival tactics. While many large companies have withdrawn from the city, small businesses struggle to stay afloat, and most commerce operates in underground markets. Supermarkets and shopping centers are boarded up, replaced by black-market trade and barter systems. Greenwashing persists in corporate messaging, but in reality, waste management has collapsed, and sustainability efforts are nonexistent. In a city abandoned by mainstream commerce, survival replaces consumerism as the economic norm.

Construction & Architecture

The city is a crumbling skyline, with abandoned high-rises standing alongside old industrial structures. Vertical sprawl dominates, but poorly maintained modular buildings are collapsing, their facades patched with cheap repairs. Green initiatives like rooftop gardens and urban forests have mostly failed, leaving concrete wastelands. Buildings are rigid, unable to adapt to changing needs, as outdated codes and lack of investment stifle innovation. The city's aesthetic is one of stagnation and neglect.

Infrastructure & Energy

The city’s infrastructure is a patchwork of failing systems. The power grid operates sporadically, with rolling blackouts becoming part of daily life. Water shortages are frequent, and waste disposal is almost nonexistent, creating toxic living conditions. Renewable energy projects have stalled due to lack of funding, leaving fossil fuels as the dominant energy source, worsening pollution. Cyberattacks and system failures are common, exposing the vulnerability of outdated infrastructure. The once-modern city now relies on unstable, makeshift solutions to keep basic services running.

Legislation & Governance

Governance is a shadow play of power: corporations draft policies, while governments rubber-stamp them. Policies are outdated and rarely enforced, and city planning exists in name only. Corruption and mismanagement have left regulatory systems ineffective, creating a power vacuum where criminal organizations fill the gaps. Zoning laws are disregarded, leading to uncontrolled urban sprawl and worsening living conditions. Public resistance exists, but protests are met with indifference rather than repression. With no clear leadership or strategy for recovery, the city remains in a downward spiral, trapped in stagnation and neglect.



Examples of Today:



Johannesburg, South Africa

Facing severe water shortages due to mismanagement and infrastructure failures, residents endure prolonged supply cuts. Critical services like hospitals are impacted, and the economy risks significant downturns. [Link](#)



Gary, USA

Gary epitomizes post-industrial decay. Abandoned factories, vacant homes, and failing infrastructure dominate. High poverty and crime rates persist, while revitalization efforts fail. The city remains a stark example of urban collapse. [Link](#)



Kinshasa, Democratic Republic of the Congo

Overwhelmed by rapid growth, lacks basic infrastructure like clean water and electricity. Corruption and weak governance exacerbate poverty and informal settlements, leaving the city in perpetual crisis. Urban failure defines daily life. [Link](#)

The city, once a beacon of progress, is now a fractured maze of failure and decay. Neighborhoods become isolated, their borders rigid, as survival depends on remaining privilege. The failure to adapt has turned urban life into a daily struggle—where basic needs are luxuries, and hope is scarce.

Can this context be bridged to find new ways, or is collapse inevitable? Who benefits from this fractured system, and who pays the price? And in a place where survival overshadows prosperity, where does happiness still exist, and what does it look like?